

NFL Innovation HUB: 2025 Program Design

Overview

The NFL Innovation HUB is the League's engine for identifying, testing, and scaling transformative technologies and solutions that support league operations, enhance the fan experience, and drive long-term value. For 2025, the HUB will operate across three interconnected program models, with this year serving as a pilot to test and refine our approach.

1. NFL Innovation Challenges

Purpose: Curated end-to-end pipeline for sourcing, testing, and scaling high-impact innovations aligned to strategic league priorities.

Structure:

- 2025 will serve as a pilot year with one flagship challenge, with the goal of scaling to 2–3 annually in future years.
- Multi-phase process: problem framing → participant sourcing (startups, mid-size firms, ecosystem players) → pilot testing → final showcase.
- Each challenge includes a league stakeholder champion and a jointly-led team with N-Ovate and NFL co-owning program design and execution.
- Includes event logistics planning and facilitation for final showcases and workshops.

Funding:

- Co-funded by league departments or innovation-designated funds.
- Challenge-specific budget allocations recommended.

NOVATE's Role:

- Co-design the challenge with NFL leaders (RACI-based collaboration).
- Lead participant sourcing, pilot coordination, and data capture.
- Deliver event logistics and end-of-challenge reporting, including scalability recommendations.

2. NFL Co-Create Program

Purpose: Partner-driven innovation model allowing sponsors and approved partners to collaborate with the NFL on disruptive technologies.

Structure: (Two tracks)

- **Sponsored POC Track:** Internal NFL leaders nominate use cases. These are executed with sponsor support (e.g., VC model).
- **Partner-Funded Co-Create:** To be explored with Steering Committee approval—potential for non-sponsor partner POCs with strict guidelines. *All communications involving sponsors will be coordinated in collaboration with NFL Sponsorship to ensure alignment.*

Funding:

- Primarily funded via NFL sponsorship partners or internal innovation budgets.

NOVATE's Role:

- Engage with sponsors to align on innovation goals and create joint execution plans.
- Design and manage project sprints in collaboration with League and partner.
- Support communications planning with Sponsorship, ensuring messaging alignment and coordination.

3. Operationalization & Change Management

Purpose: Apply HUB infrastructure to internal priorities by providing R&D, prototyping, and rapid launch capabilities.

Types of Projects:

- Internal tech integrations or POCs that impact multiple departments.
- Adoption/change initiatives that benefit from an agile prototype-first approach.
- Use HUB resources to quickly de-risk and validate approaches before broader implementation.

Funding:

- Primarily funded through internal NFL departmental allocations.

NOVATE's Role:

- Act as R&D and implementation resource to IT and BRM functions.

- Provide flexible innovation and testing capacity not replacing business relationship management but enabling fast-cycle discovery.
- Document findings and translate into reusable frameworks for enterprise-wide adoption.

Cross-Cutting Infrastructure

Program Admin & Support (Led by N-Ovate):

- Program Director and Operations Analyst manage cross-program coordination.
- Intern Cohort and NIN Partners support surge capacity and execution.
- Event, data, and pilot logistics managed centrally.

Calendar & Governance:

- Annual calendar aligns with League priorities.
- Monthly governance reviews to manage resource allocation and delivery velocity.

Monetization & Resource Strategy:

- Sponsorship tiers to be explored for specific event-based innovation (e.g., challenges).
- Overall HUB funding model is based on internal investment and co-creation alignment.
- Tech-in-kind contributions (e.g., APIs, software, devices) may be provided by sponsors to power a 'Hub Lab'—a central R&D environment managed by NOVATE